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MY POWAI

Volume No. 14 Issue No. 08 Mumbai April 2026



Dear friends

April arrives with a sense of release. Exams are over, vacations are calling and summer has settled in. Evenings now belong to the excitement of the Indian Premier League, a season that brings us together.

In this issue of My Powai, Sherry Bhatnagar takes us on a beautiful journey with kheer, not just as a recipe, but as a timeless thread that connects generations, memories, and moments. Our nutritionist, Nisha Singh challenges a common belief with a thought-provoking take on why eating less doesn't necessarily lead to weight loss, while our astrologer, Richa Pathak gives a glimpse of what the zodiac signs have in store.

And then there's a delightful slice of life from Girija Menon, who observes with warmth and wit the many types of morning walkers we encounter every day. Adding further depth to this issue are engaging pieces by DPK Udas, Debika Chaudhuri, and Palak Sardana — each bringing their own unique voice and perspective.

As always, this magazine is as much yours as it is ours. We would love to hear what you think, what stayed with you, and what you'd like to see more of.

Until then, here's wishing you a summer filled with good stories, great food and memorable journeys.

Happy Reading!

Warm regards,
Mahesh Kutty
(Editor)

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BMC budget 2026 – What's in it for Powai?



D.P.K. Udas

Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation has presented its budget for 2026–27.

There is an overall increase in the budget outlay. To meet various expenses, in addition to regular revenue, earlier fixed deposits are proposed to be liquidated. The capital expenditure is a whopping ₹48,164 crore — but nothing specifically for Powai.

Major allocations include:
Coastal Road – ₹950 crore
GMLR – ₹255 crore
Storm Water Drains – ₹80 crore
Roads & Bridges – ₹9,050 crore

For years, Powai residents have been requesting the following:
- A tunnel underneath Powai Hills to ease traffic
- A giant air purifier to improve AQI

Skywalks:
(a) IIT Metro Station to MTNL Office
(b) Rambaug Metro Station to Chandivali Farm Road
- Satellite zoo at Dr Ambedkar Nisarg Udyan
- Community hall & gymkhana
- Drama theatre
- Playground

However, none of these have been included.

That said, there are a few allocations where S Ward and L Ward stand to benefit:

A) Basic Amenities & Civil Repairs
S Ward – ₹28 crore
L Ward – ₹40 crore

This allocation is higher than most other wards, which fall in the ₹15–20 crore range.

B) New Office for S Ward
The S Ward office will move from Bhandup to a new building in Kanjur. ₹14 crore has been allocated for this shift.

C) Gaothan Development
Several small villages in the area will receive ₹10 crore each for road widening and paving:

Tirandaz
Tunga
Hariyali
Mohili
Sai Pangoda Adivasi Pada
Asalfa



D) MCMCR
The MCGM Centre for Municipal Capacity Building & Research (MCMCR), located in the MHADA complex facing Powai Lake near Union Bank, will be air-conditioned and the surrounding area beautified. Allocation: ₹31 crore.

E) Prefabricated Public Toilets
To improve convenience for commuters, prefabricated public toilets will be installed. ₹10 crore each has been allocated for L Ward and S Ward.

F) Upgradation of Gardens
L Ward – ₹2.68 crore
S Ward – ₹1.69 crore

G) Playgrounds
The overall budget for playgrounds has increased significantly — from ₹1.7 crore to ₹150 crore. Local corporators must now follow up to ensure open plots are converted into playgrounds.

Projects that may indirectly benefit Powai residents:
GMLR (Goregaon–Mulund Link Road)
This will reduce the load on JVLR and ease congestion.

Coastal Road
Its extension up to Versova will provide an additional connection, reducing dependence on routes via Bandra and easing traffic on the Western Express Highway.

Resurfacing of EEH & WEH
Provisions have been made to resurface the Eastern and Western Express Highways, promising smoother commutes.

Projects in other wards that Powai also deserves:
Juhu: Multipurpose community hall & gymkhana
A Ward: Footpath beautification with decorative lighting and planters (₹5 crore allocated)

The question remains — why not Powai?

(The author is long time resident of Powai. He takes up civic issues with the authorities. He has been instrumental in improving illumination in the area, zebra crossings , garbage removal etc.)



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DivaDash: From 7 women to 100... and counting

Every movement has a moment it was born. For DivaDash, that moment was March 6, 2022 (Sunday)—when **Smita Sahai** stepped out of her building, water bottle in hand, and asked a handful of women to join her for a run. No frills. No registration. No medals. Just 7–8 women, a stretch of road, and a simple idea—what if we rooted for each other while we ran?

Smita had been running loops around her society for years—a working mother of two, she'd long made peace with the fact that long-distance training far from home wasn't always possible. So she ran close to home. And on International Women's Day, she thought: why run alone?

Each woman set her own target. Each ran her own race. And somewhere between the heavy breathing and cheering each other on, something quietly powerful was born. They called it the IWD Run.

Then came 2024—and Pallavi Praseed.



When the idea found resonance with Pallavi and a few other women in the society, it didn't just grow. It transformed. Smita and Pallavi came together as great partners, each bringing her own energy, strengths, and vision to the table. *What followed was the kind of collaboration that only happens when people are equally invested, equally passionate, and equally unwilling to think small.*

The IWD Run became **DivaDash.** Suddenly, there were T-shirts. Bibs. Medals. Refreshments. Trainer tie-ups. Sponsors. And 50 women showing up with fire in their eyes. It was, by every measure, an overnight success—but really, it was years in the making.

What Smita had seeded with quiet conviction, she and Pallavi together grew into a movement.

2026: Bigger. Bolder. Louder. Two women. One vision. Unstoppable together.

DivaDash is back—and she came dressed for the occasion.
115 women. Sold out (we had to cap it—the response was that overwhelming). **5 sponsors. 12 associate partners.** And a tribe that shows up not just to run, but to lift every woman beside her.

Homemakers, professionals, entrepreneurs—women who spend all day pouring into others—are lacing up their shoes and choosing themselves. On their own turf. In their own community. On their day.

DivaDash isn't just a run. It's proof that when women come together—really come together—extraordinary things happen.

From 7 women and a water bottle to a movement that's just getting started.

This is the DivaDash Tribe. And we're only going faster.



The April habit that built wealth

Every April, Rajiv had a small ritual. Before the new financial year settled into its rhythm, he would sit with his notebook and plan how to use his **₹1.5 lakh deduction under Section 80C.**

A little went into **Public Provident Fund,** some into **Equity Linked Savings Scheme,** a part into **National Savings Certificate,** and of course **Life Insurance** for family protection. At first, Rajiv thought he was doing it just to **save tax.** But something interesting happened over the years. That yearly planning slowly built **discipline.** His savings grew. His investments diversified. His financial confidence improved. The **old tax regime** quietly nudged people like Rajiv into building a saving habit.

Today, under the **new tax regime**, things are different. There are **lower tax rates but fewer deductions.** Investments are no longer pushed by tax benefits. The responsibility shifts completely to the individual. In a way, the question has changed. Earlier it was: "How do I save tax?" Today it is: "How do I grow my money?" And that requires something deeper than deductions — **awareness, planning, and discipline.**

Quick Snapshot: Old vs New vs Tax Regime		
Aspect	**Old Tax Regime**	**New Tax Regime**
Tax Rates	Higher	Lower
Deductions	Available (80C, 80D etc.)	Not Available
Savings Habit	Encouraged through tax benefits	Self-driven discipline required
Investment Approach	Structured	Flexible

Where People Invested Under 80C

Common tax-saving instruments included:

- **Equity Linked Savings Scheme (ELSS)**
- **Public Provident Fund (PPF), NPS**
- **National Savings Certificate (NSC)**
- **Life Insurance**

Though capped at **₹1.5 lakh per year,** these investments often became the **starting point of long-term wealth creation.**

The Real Opportunity Today

With the new regime, individuals may have **higher disposable income.** But wealth doesn't grow from income alone. It grows from **intentional planning.**

A thoughtful mix of **equity, debt, insurance and emergency savings** — combined with discipline — creates financial stability.

The Real Lesson

Tax rules may change every few years. But one principle never changes: People who plan their money early eventually give their life more choices. Financial planning is not about tax seasons. It is about life seasons.

- Uma Kumaravelan
Certified Financial Planner
www.oaktree.in



Cultural and historical Pune

When I planned a visit to Pune, I decided to explore the cultural and historical side of the city, which was first ruled by the Muslims and later taken over by the Marathas in the 17th century.

My daughter and I boarded the Metro early in the morning. It was packed to capacity, as it was office time. After one and a half hours, we alighted at the station near Jadhavgarh, a fort that has been converted into a hotel.

After having breakfast at a popular restaurant, we booked a cab to the fort. On reaching, we were welcomed in a royal manner with the beating of drums and the sound of a bugle.

We then proceeded on a climb to the fort hotel, which is located at the top, with steep stone steps leading to the reception. We were greeted by a traditionally dressed receptionist who applied haldi-kumkum on our foreheads. We were offered a lemon drink before completing the formalities. Then we were shown our room after climbing another flight of stone steps. The structure had walls like a fort made of stone, while the interiors had modern amenities.

After lunch, we explored the fort, which had a gallery overlooking a lush garden. We retired after tea and an early dinner.

The next day, we climbed up the steps to the breakfast room, which had different sections named after cities like Pune, Mumbai, etc. Old Marathi songs were being played.

We checked out with fond memories of the fort, which was built by King Pilaji Jadhav Rao in 1710, a valiant Maratha general, for residential purposes. It has 42 rooms, 12 tents, and 4 NERM forest cottages.



Our next stop was a museum, about an hour and a half from Jadhavgarh Fort. After buying tickets, we proceeded inside the museum named Zapurza, which also had an auditorium where cultural activities and programs were held.



First, we visited a section where film pictures were displayed, ranging from the silent era to modern movies by famous productions like Prabhat, initiated by V. Shantaram. There was also a video showing a popular song performed by child artists.

Next was a section displaying silverware and artifacts from different regions like Uttar Pradesh, Kashmir, Karachi, and Maharashtra. Then there was a section showcasing sarees from various parts of India, along with demonstrations of how they are woven by hand.

The next section focused on pottery and the process of making it. Lastly, there was a store where handicrafts were on sale.

The museum was surrounded by a garden with statues of humans, cows decorated in gold, a tiger, and scrap materials crafted into animal figures.

We had a meal at a canteen named Pune Guest House.

We returned fulfilled, having experienced the cultural and historical side of Pune — a city known as an educational hub and home to several artists and performers from across the globe.

- Preeti oka

The vanishing art of dialogue: Why our words feel shallower in the digital age



Debika Chaudhuri

Dialogue used to be something we entered into. Today, it's often something we get through.

About 30 years ago, most conversations required presence. You called someone on a landline and stayed on the phone. You sat across from people at dinner tables, in classrooms, on park benches. Dialogue had a natural rhythm, pauses, interruptions, laughter, even awkward silences. These weren't flaws; they were part of how we understood each other. When someone said "I'm fine," you could hear whether they really were.

Writers like Ernest Hemingway and Anton Chekhov built entire worlds on the idea that what is unsaid in dialogue often matters more than what is spoken. And that only works when people are truly present with each other.

Today, much of our communication feels more like notifications, quick pings, glanced at, responded to, and cleared. Conversations resemble instant food: efficient, convenient, and immediately satisfying, but rarely something we sit with. Emotions, too, get compressed into this format, reduced to short texts, emojis, or replies that are expected to be instant, often emotionless.

- You message a colleague: "Joining the meeting?" Response - "Yes."
- You text a friend: "Reached home?" Response - "Yep."
- You order food, track it, rate it, without speaking to a single person.

These are dialogues, but they are purely transactional. Their purpose is to complete a task, not to build understanding.

Even in more personal spaces, this shift shows up:

- Family groups on messaging apps: Instead of long conversations, you see forwarded messages, emojis, or quick acknowledgments like □".
- Friendships: Plans are made through short bursts of texts, but deeper conversations get postponed indefinitely, "We'll talk properly when we meet."
- Workplace chats: Communication is efficient but stripped of tone, often leading to misunderstandings. A simple "Okay." can feel supportive, neutral, or passive-aggressive depending on how it's read.

This is what George Bernard Shaw meant when he said the biggest problem in communication is the illusion that it has taken place. We feel like we've talked, but often we've only exchanged signals.



The change isn't just in medium it's in mindset. Dialogue is increasingly treated as a tool for efficiency rather than a space for exploration, but here's why it still matters, perhaps more than ever.

Real dialogue is how we understand people beyond their surface responses. It's the difference between:

- Asking a friend "How are you?" over text and moving on after "Fine."

vs.

Sitting with them and saying, "You don't sound fine, what's going on?"

- Telling a teammate "Fix this." on chat

vs.

Talking through why something isn't working and hearing their perspective

- Reacting instantly to a disagreement online

vs.

Taking time to ask, "What do you mean by that?"

When dialogue becomes a series of short, transactional bursts, emotions start adapting to that rhythm:

- Feelings get abbreviated: "I'm fine," "It's okay," "No worries," even when they're not true
- Vulnerability gets pushed to the back burner: "We'll talk properly when we meet," but that moment keeps getting delayed
- Misunderstandings increase: tone is guessed, not heard
- Loneliness can grow quietly: despite constant communication, people may feel unseen or unheard

As Robert McKee put it, dialogue is not just conversation, it is action. It's where relationships are shaped, conflicts are worked through, and trust is built.

In contrast, earlier dialogue, like a living room conversation allowed emotions to breathe. You could sit in silence with someone. You could notice hesitation. You could ask, "What's really going on?" That kind of presence made it harder for emotions to be dismissed or overlooked.

Today, many conversations resemble a scrolling feed or short clips, fragmented, fast, and easily replaced. Emotional moments appear briefly and disappear just as quickly. We react, but we don't process. We acknowledge, but we don't always engage.

And yet, the importance of dialogue has only grown.

In a world of constant communication, meaningful dialogue is one of the few spaces where emotions can still be fully experienced and understood. As Robert McKee said, dialogue is not just conversation it is action. It's where emotional realities are revealed, not just reported.

Digital tools are not the problem, they've simply made shallow dialogue easier and deep dialogue more intentional. Today, meaningful conversation requires choosing to slow down when everything around us is designed for speed.

(The author, Debika Chaudhuri, runs Elzix Foundation, an Educational Consultancy for the past twelve years. She has studied across three continents and has close to three decades of experience as an Executive Educator and Career Coach. She and her team help young people make important choices at critical junctures of their lives; develop self-confidence, if they don't know what to do; help develop their skills to make the right fit; create life-changing educational experiences and help them with college admissions. She may be reached at debikac@elzixfoundation.com)

The unofficial syllabus of growing up



Chaarvi Athawale

Dear someone in Powai,

You might be a student in a classroom right now, nodding at something important while mentally calculating how you could possibly pencil in a game of basketball during the day. Or you might be in your final semester, where every conversation casually includes phrases like "after this" and "what next beta?," as if the future were a group project nobody volunteered for but everyone is somehow part of.

Growing up in Powai, life came with a syllabus for me. It was comforting, routine, and quite frankly, monotonous. You know the chapters, the weightage, the teacher, their style of marking and roughly how much panic was appropriate before each exam. Naturally, I assumed adulthood would follow the same model, perhaps a little more complex, but still structured. Lesson 1: Confidence, you're out there in the world! Lesson 2: Stability, let the bills roll in. Lesson 3: Have your life together by a reasonable deadline, go on the occasional vacation.

Boy, did adulthood misplace the entire curriculum. I was in for a rude awakening - I was slapped with a bunch of lessons you don't realize you're learning until you're halfway through them.

Chapter 1: Coffee Becomes Functional

At some point, coffee stops being a social activity and becomes infrastructure. You don't drink it for taste, you drink it to become operational, functional, to stop yourself from looking like a cast member from The Walking Dead. You start respecting mornings. You start saying things like, "I shouldn't sleep so late," which is the linguistic equivalent of realizing you've crossed into a new phase of life. The paradox is painfully subtle: you spent years wanting independence, and now you voluntarily create routines that look suspiciously like the discipline you once resisted.



Chapter 2: Money Develops a Personality

The first paycheck feels like a triumph. Your first stack of green, all to yourself, no conditions attached, no strict parents setting a grade benchmark for the things you always wanted.

You briefly consider becoming financially responsible overnight. Then expenses appear, and money transforms from a concept into a disappearing act. You begin doing mental arithmetic in grocery stores. You discover the joy of "free delivery." You realize adulthood is all about watching the money politely leave, leaving you confused. For the longest time, financial independence meant you could finally spend your own money. No one prepped you for the guilt you feel immediately after. Oh well.

Chapter 3: Professional Nodding Neck Disorder (PNND)

You enter meetings. You listen. You nod thoughtfully. You say, "That's interesting," which could mean anything from genuine agreement to "I need a few more seconds to understand", or "Don't talk to me before my morning coffee." At first, it feels like you're pretending, a reaction unique to you. Then you realize everyone else is also nodding with equal conviction. Adulthood, at the end of the day, is a room full of people collaboratively acting like they know what's happening. The reality? Most of them don't have the slightest clue.



Chapter 4: The Myth of Having It Figured Out

Growing up, you assume adults possess clarity. Then you become one and realize clarity is mostly good posture and excellent positioning of words – "Let's circle back", "Let's solidify our position", "I like to think of it as a strategic benefit". Well-dressed pauses and spiffy phrases.

Chapter 5: The Daily Decision Marathon

No one mentions that adulthood is largely made up of small decisions. What to eat. When to sleep. Whether to go out. Whether to stay in. None of these feel significant individually, yet together they form the architecture of your life. Freedom sounds exciting until you realize it includes choosing dinner every single day, labouring over the smallest tasks.

The funny thing? You've craved choice, and now you occasionally wish someone would just hand you a menu, a tray of steaming food, and a blanket.

Chapter 6: Missing Structure, Then Accidentally Rebuilding It

There comes a moment when you almost miss having a timetable. No semesters, no official checkpoints, just open-ended weeks. Sure, you'll be chasing targets, some impossible, some that you smash, some that you're not quite able to meet, but the days are yours to structure.

Initially, this feels like freedom. Then you start making lists. You set reminders. You create routines. Slowly, you rebuild structure, except this time you're the one designing it. And then one day it dawns, nice and bright, adulthood is escaping structure, only to reconstruct it voluntarily.

Somewhere between these chapters, another realization quietly appears: nobody is entirely prepared. The people who seem composed are simply more comfortable learning in real time. Everyone is adjusting, recalibrating, and occasionally pretending they planned it this way all along.

And this is where you come in, someone in Powai, whether you're in a lecture, finishing your degree, struggling with an internship, starting off your first work stint, or just starting to think about what comes next. The syllabus doesn't end when you leave the classroom. It just changes format to one that has a lot less boundaries, but a lot more ground to cover.

One day, without any announcement, you'll realize you've covered several chapters already. You will still be improvising, still adjusting, but also laughing at the strange paradox of it all: we spent years preparing for adulthood, only to discover that adulthood is mostly preparation, ongoing, slightly chaotic, and surprisingly funny.

And before you know it, you'll be introducing this syllabus of life to someone else, just like me, flipping through the chapters, laughing, and hoping the next one doesn't involve taxes.

Fitness without food awareness: The missing link in urban sports culture

In today's urban world, fitness has become more visible than ever. From step counters and calorie trackers to gym memberships and workout challenges, staying active is often seen as the ultimate marker of a healthy lifestyle. Social media is filled with people sharing their workout routines, progress photos, and daily step counts. But in all this focus on movement, there is one critical piece that often gets overlooked — food awareness.

Many people assume that as long as they are exercising regularly, they are doing enough to stay healthy. However, this belief can be misleading. Fitness is not just about how much you move, but also about how you fuel your body.

Urban fitness culture tends to prioritize visible effort. Burning calories, completing workouts, and hitting fitness goals are celebrated. Nutrition, on the other hand, is quieter and less visible. It does not show up in step counts or workout summaries, which makes it easier to ignore. As a result, many active individuals struggle to see results, feel constantly tired, or even face health issues despite being physically active.

The reason is simple: exercise and nutrition are deeply interconnected. When we exercise, our bodies require proper fuel to perform and recover. Without the right balance of nutrients, workouts can become less effective. For example, not consuming enough protein can slow muscle recovery, while inadequate carbohydrates can lead to low energy levels during workouts. Similarly, a lack of essential vitamins and minerals can affect everything from stamina to overall well-being.

Another issue is the widespread misunderstanding of "healthy eating." In urban settings, people are often surrounded by quick, convenient food options that are marketed as healthy but may not provide balanced nutrition. Skipping meals, relying on processed "fitness foods," or following extreme diets can all negatively impact results, even if someone is working out regularly.

Food awareness is not about strict dieting or counting every calorie. It is about understanding what your body needs and making informed choices. This includes knowing the importance of balanced meals, staying hydrated, and recognizing how different foods affect energy, mood, and performance.

Bridging the gap between fitness and nutrition can make a significant difference. When people combine regular exercise with mindful eating, they are more likely to see sustainable results. They feel stronger, recover faster, and maintain better overall health.

Urban sports culture is slowly evolving, but there is still a long way to go. Gyms, schools, and fitness communities need to place equal emphasis on nutrition education. Encouraging conversations around food, rather than just workouts, can help individuals develop a more complete understanding of health.

At the end of the day, fitness is not just about how much you move, but how well you support your body. Exercise may be the visible part of the journey, but food awareness is the foundation that makes everything else work. Only when both come together can we truly complete the fitness picture.

- Anushka Bahorey
Grade 11,
Singapore International School (Mumbai)



Morning walkers of Powai



Girija Menon

When you stop walking, you start noticing. That is the side I write this story from.

There was a time when I was one of them – a morning walker.

Back during my work years, morning walks were not poetic. They were practical. You walked because the day demanded structure. Because a desk awaited. Because time was not elastic. Schedules had to fit into a specific time bracket.

Retirement, or what we politely call "after work," changed that. Suddenly, I could choose my hour. I could walk later combining walk, errands, catching up with friends or just for the sake of getting a good click that translated to poetry.

Observing to create stories has and will always be the most interesting part of my walks.

Now my morning begins with coffee by the window. From there, I watch this familiar tribe step into the day. Some have been doing this for years. Same pace. Same route. Same quiet commitment. Powai provides patches of green canvas. The walkers paint the stories.

The Fast and the Brisk

These are the purposeful ones. Quick steps. Swinging arms. Eyes straight ahead. I often wonder who they are outside this stretch of pavement. Go-getters? Former executives? People who still measure their worth in efficiency? Their walk feels like a continuation of a life lived with intent. No drifting. No distractions. Just forward motion You sense that even their thoughts move briskly. Easy to see and easier to understand from the body language.

The Runners

Rain, heat, humidity. It doesn't matter. They show up. Running is not exercise for them. It is ritual. Almost devotion. The kind that says, I will meet myself here every morning, no excuses. There's something deeply reassuring about that consistency. Passion wrapped in sweat and discipline. Those who start running and are consistent in a way fall in love with running as I believe it changes perception to life.

The Headphone Walkers and Runners

They move in a world of their own. Some are listening to music, I imagine. Something soothing. Perhaps old film songs. Perhaps instrumental ragas or spiritual bits that help them throughout the day. A morning discourse. A chant maybe. And others, I suspect, are absorbing podcasts. Learning. Reflecting. Expanding. What fascinates me is that they are physically present in this beautiful space we call home, but mentally travelling elsewhere. And yet, the rhythm of their feet remains perfectly in sync with the mood, the trees, the morning air or the chaos that grows as the day evolves.

The Couples

There are many. Some walk slowly, happily chatting. No rush. No visible stress. The conversation seems easy, unforced. They must have found their rhythm long ago. Then there are the quieter pairs. Together, but walking alone. Side by side, yet wrapped in private thoughts. It makes you wonder. Is it comfort? Is it distance? Or is it simply the kind of silence that only they understand? In either case, the walk becomes shared time. And shared time is no small thing – a thought worth mulling over.

The Feeders

The ones who carry biscuits for stray dogs. Or grains for birds. There is tenderness in that act. A quiet connection that pulls them out every morning. Perhaps it gives them purpose. Perhaps it gives them company. Either way, the exchange is wordless but meaningful. They probably see joy in the eyes of those they feed and that feels divine.

The Errand Walkers

Milk in one hand. Cloth bag in another. They merge exercise with responsibility. A quick stop at the local store, maybe near the lanes leading towards vegetable or fruit vendors. For them, walking is practical. Efficient. Yet even they cannot escape the freshness of the hour.

The Grandparents

And then, the sight that melts you. A grandparent walking a child to school. Small fingers wrapped around larger ones. The adult adjusting the backpack. The child skipping ahead. That short stretch of road holds generations. You could write an entire story just about that walk. About time folding into itself. Whatever the category, the benefits are obvious. Fresh air for the lungs. Green gardens for the eyes. An early start that quietly organises the day before it begins to demand things from you. But what this really means is something deeper.

Walking keeps the body steady. It clears the mind. And for the soul, it is almost essential. When all three are tended to, life feels less chaotic.

In Powai, nature is always present. Sometimes in the background. Sometimes boldly in the foreground. The lake reflects the sky. The trees soften the skyline of Hiranandani Gardens. Yet the true canter stage belongs to the walkers.

Each one carries a private universe. Responsibilities. Memories. Hopes. Regrets. Plans. From my window, coffee in hand, I watch them and weave quiet stories. That is my morning ritual these days. And perhaps that is how connections are born.

Life linking itself to the everyday sunrise
Watching a crimson horizon – today indeed a prize

In the end, whether we walk or watch, we are all part of the same unfolding awesome promising morning.

(Girija Menon, the author, enjoys her passion for writing. Her first love is poetry; an astute observer of the world around us, she loves writing down her thoughts in both poems and prose. LIFE THREADS is what she uses to weave this one-of-a-kind fabric that spans reams. She can be reached at – whisperingverses@gmail.com)



Dopamine Hijack

Rescue strategies _Environmental design (Part2)



Palak Sardana

If there is any commodity that every conglomerate worth its salt is vying for, it is your time and attention. In the previous article we explored how products and services are being pushed to consumers by tapping into their dopamine circuit. This isn't anything new, but the dangers we face today because of incessant exposure to screens, is unprecedented. An average person checks their phone anywhere between 7-10 times every waking hour and that's alarming.

Being glued to technology and gadgets is a behavioural addiction impacting the same way as alcohol or drug addiction would. The hallmark brain change of these addictions is the desensitisation to dopamine (discussed at length in the earlier article) resulting in various intensity of emotional and mental upheavals. Online gaming & gambling, social media, short-format videos, adult, titillating & rage baiting content are all designed around instant dopamine hikes that puts a person's mind on a hamster's wheel, running fast but reaching nowhere in particular, leading to dopamine abuse and culminating in intense mental & often physical exhaustion.

In my work as a counsellor, I often encounter concerned & fearful parents and adults reflecting guilt and displaying helplessness in their ability to rescue their children, family members & many-a-times themselves from succumbing to extended online hours. I wish to send out this message to anyone feeling this way right now that it is not you, your intention or efforts (or lack of it), but the very design, architecture and the content of online platforms that has most of us in its grip. The teams behind these designs employ some of the smartest and most sophisticated brains like that of neuroscientists from Ivy league colleges to capture the young, tender, vulnerable & unaware minds who have no idea how their brains are being engaged and locked in when they are looking at their screens.

Being a yoga teacher, I truly believe that one needs the yog-proficiency of no less than Lord Shiva to come out of the Maya-jaal (web of illusions) spun out by extremely clever tech entrepreneurs who at any cost & by any tactic, want to capture your attention & commoditise and sell it further to marketers and advertisers. Hence, be easy & have compassion for yourself and your loved ones as you strive for redemption from the clutches of online addiction & compulsiveness.



Though there are no fool proof methods yet to breakout of the omnipresence & influence of smart phones and gadgets, with awareness and some tactical processes, there can surely be some hope.

Environmental design of your immediate surroundings can make a significant difference in the pattern of gadget-usage. A supportive environment is one that makes the compulsive use of gadgets annoying & difficult and intentional use easy.

Creating a physical distance from the gadgets can be a good starting point. E.g. no gadgets during meals & sleep time, gadget free bedrooms, keeping the phone physically away when working or studying, a no-gadget rule during family get togethers can be adapted together as families ensuring these rules apply to everyone & not just children. Having a dedicated 'parking spot' for gadgets (especially phones), using an alarm clock instead of the phone, putting the phone on airplane mode a couple of hours before sleep time are just some ideas worth exploring to check their efficacy.

Removing the most distracting apps from home screen and moving them to app library or hiding them can hinder their compulsive access. Deleting them from your phone and installing them on your PC is a bit more radical and can further restrict the access.

Guarding the first hour after waking and the final hour before sleep is imperative for a more stable mind. Replacing the phone usage with a mindful rival behaviour like meditation, breathwork, reading, journaling, mantra chanting, cuddling your pet, self-massage or mild stretching is helpful. These activities have a calming effect on the nervous system & can pave way for a more organised day or a deep and restful sleep, depending upon when it is done.

Our phones are multi-taskers and hence can deviate our attention in various directions in a nick. Moving to one-purpose devices wherever possible, like using watches or clocks to monitor time or using physical note books for making notes can help in maintaining elongated focus during work hours.

Putting a sticky note on the phone when you reach out for it asking "what are you picking me up for?" can be a good reminder to move from impulse to awareness.

There is no overnight cure; only shared light. As we continue to explore other strategies in upcoming editions, let's be aware that we are in this together—so let us keep exchanging what heals, trying what helps, and learning as we go.

(Palak Sardana is a Harvard certified wellness coach, a mental health counsellor, yoga teacher & founder of wellness venture, Tranquility Unlimited. Via these articles, her endeavour is to present non-invasive & practical models of wellness grounded in ancient wisdom and modern scientific research. She runs ongoing wellness classes. For joining or booking a personalized consultation/session, write to tranquilityunlimited@gmail.com)

Why "Eating Less" is not helping you to lose weight



Nisha Singh

One of the most common complaints I hear in my clinical practice is this, "I eat healthy, I exercise regularly and yet I don't lose weight" or the other version of this same complaint, "I have gained weight in the past few months, I have reduced my intake yet my weight isn't moving".

There is a very big and fundamental problem in both these statements.

Despite cutting portions, skipping desserts, exercising more, the weight does not move. Or it may even increase. This frustrates even more since it goes against the most common idea that's fed into the general psyche - eat less, move more and you will lose weight.

Only if it were so simple and straightforward.

The body is much smarter and much more complex than we can fathom. It's wired for survival. It may protect, it may adapt and it may even resist.

At the heart of the issue lies your metabolism - it's a very delicate and intricate system that determines how the body uses energy.

When one significantly reduces the food intake, your body doesn't respond by accelerating fat loss. Instead, it does something quite remarkable: it adapts.

This phenomenon, known as adaptive thermogenesis, has been consistently observed in metabolic research. Studies show that when calorie intake drops, the body compensates by reducing energy expenditure—sometimes by as much as 100 to 180 calories per day within the first week alone.

It's a subtle, but meaningful shift. This is your body adapting.
Eventually, this leads to slow metabolism. In other words the rate at which the weight reduces drops. In reality, scientifically speaking, the body has become more efficient. It's burning fewer calories and conserving energy. It's continuing its core task.

Then comes the next part. Losing muscle instead of just fat.

When you eat too little, the body uses not only fat but also muscle stores to draw energy. In fact it's easier for the body to break muscle. It always chooses to conserve fat and use it as the last resort. Muscle mass plays a major role in not only keeping your metabolism but also your metabolic rate - the energy that is burned when not doing any activity, high.

Lose muscle and you drop your metabolism even further. Thus negating all your efforts. This is one of the reasons why diets with too many restrictions or even over exercising for that matter aren't sustainable for the long term.

Another aspect to this complex situation are hormones. Weight management is actually hormone management. There are several key hormones that play an important role and when restrictive diets or lifestyles are undertaken, a major pushback comes from your hormones.



An elaborate interplay of hormones kicks in when you continuously undereat. The stress hormone cortisol increases since the body reads this state as "deprivation" and puts in place steps to protect fat and conserve energy. It's a stress signal to the body and inflammation levels rise. The hunger hormone ghrelin rises, constantly telling the body to eat whereas the satiety hormone - leptin decreases. This causes the body to feel increased cravings. Then comes insulin, their levels reduce. This impacts the overall metabolism. And for females, their reproductive hormones too come into the picture. Estrogen drops leading to central obesity.

Apart from hormones and metabolism, there is one other aspect - NEAT - Non exercise activity thermogenesis. This is the energy that is used in activities such as walking, sitting, chopping vegetables etc. Over a period of time you may realise that you feel the need to sit longer, walk less and so on.

The reason is that due to undereating the body is constantly in an energy conservation state. Also, nutrient deficiencies can lead to fatigue and hence the need.

If every such loss of calorie burn is counted, the result can be significant.

Beyond the above mentioned factors, there are other elements as well. The lifestyle factor.

Sleep is a critical component. There's loads of research on sleep deprivation and weight gain. Short bursts of irregular sleep patterns too can disrupt hormones significantly. This can lead to improper hunger and satiety signals and more.

Stress is another very important and powerful facet. Studies have shown that chronic stress leads to increased fat storage in the body. Why? Due to constantly elevated levels of cortisol. And the fat storage is almost always around the abdomen.

Inconsistent and erratic daily routines further add fuel to this fire. Irregular eating patterns, disrupted sleep schedules, under or over exercising all increase metabolic instability.

The solution?

Balance. Always.

Shift your lifestyles and eating choices from restriction to balance and support. Instead of deprivation, adequate nourishment should be the goal. Sustainable choices are important.

Include enough protein like pulses and legumes, sprouts, dairy, eggs and fish, dried nuts and fruits. Focus on sleep. Ample sleep and rest is paramount for hormonal and therefore metabolic stability. Include stress management practices - mediation, chanting, pranayama, hobbies. Choose what speaks to you and consistently follow it. Exercise but don't overdo it. Switch the type if you have been following a particular routine for a while.

Warm, nourishing meals, easy to digest, light dinners, inclusion of herbs and spices like ginger, cumin, mint, etc. to aid good digestion which in turn supports metabolism is important. Include herb teas of fennel, cumin, carrom seeds and so on. Hydrate well.

Over and above, change the mindset.
Restrictions never work. Balance always does.
Your body is doing what it is, to protect you. Remember this always.

(The writer is a gold medalist in Food & Nutrition with more than 12 years experience. She manages various ailments through lifestyle and dietary modifications and specializes in weight loss & management. She practices at 102, Crystal Center, Raheja Vihar, Powai or Smile Craft, 23, Annapurna Industrial estate, Opp. CCD, Ghatkopar East. For appointments: 022 2857 6537 Email: singhnisha@gmail.com)

The timeless journey of Kheer: from sacred fire to silver spoon



Sherry Bhatnagar

There is something almost hypnotic about a pot of kheer gently simmering.
Milk thickens slowly, rice softens quietly, and a delicate sweetness begins to rise with the steam. The aroma is familiar, comforting—almost like a memory you didn't realize you were holding.

Long before India knew royal feasts or elaborate banquets, this very pot existed—simple, sacred, and deeply symbolic. Known as Payasa or Ksheeram in ancient Sanskrit, kheer finds its earliest mention in the Rigveda, where food was not merely consumed, but consecrated. Every ingredient carried intention. Milk symbolized purity and nurturing. Rice stood for life and sustenance. Sweetness reflected joy and abundance. Together, they created something far beyond a dish.

Kheer was pure devotion you could taste. Its significance deepens beautifully in the epic Ramayana, where kheer becomes more than symbolic—it becomes transformative. King Dasharatha, longing for children, performed a sacred yajna. From the flames emerged a divine vessel of kheer, blessed and luminous. When shared among his queens, it led to the birth of Lord Rama and his brothers.In that moment, kheer became more than nourishment.
It became hope. It became blessing.
It became the beginning of life itself.

Even today, across Indian homes, the first sweet prepared for celebrations—birthdays, festivals, new beginnings—is often kheer. Not out of habit, but instinct. Because some traditions live quietly within us.

As time unfolded, kheer began its graceful journey from temple courtyards to royal kitchens. Under the refinement of the Mughal Empire, it transformed into an expression of luxury. Saffron unfurled its golden hue, rose water added elegance, and silver leaf brought a quiet opulence. New interpretations emerged—Zafrani Kheer glowing with richness, Sheer Khurma woven with vermicelli and dates, Phirni set gently in clay bowls. Yet, even in its most indulgent form, kheer never lost its soul. It remained slow. It remained patient. It remained deeply rooted.

Across India, kheer adapted like a story told in different dialects. In Bengal, it became Payesh, fragrant with jaggery and short-grain rice. In the South, Pal Payasam simmered for hours in temple kitchens, developing a deep, caramelized warmth. Kerala's Ada Pradhaman added coconut richness, while Maharashtra brought in a subtle hint of nutmeg.

Different textures. Different flavors. But always the same feeling—comfort that settles gently within. And perhaps the truest way to understand kheer is not just to read about it, but to make it.

Traditional Rice Kheer (North Indian Style)

There is a certain stillness in preparing this version—a rhythm that slows you down.
Ingredients
1 litre full-fat milk
3 tablespoons basmati rice (washed and soaked)
4–5 tablespoons sugar
3–4 green cardamom pods
8–10 almonds and cashews
A few strands of saffron (optional)

Method
Bring milk to a gentle boil, then add the soaked rice. Lower the heat and let it cook slowly, stirring often. Watch as the milk thickens and the rice softens, almost dissolving into it. Add sugar, cardamom, and nuts, and continue cooking until it turns creamy and fragrant. Serve it warm for comfort, or chilled for quiet indulgence.

Temple-Style Pal Payasam (South Indian)

Deeper, richer, and almost meditative in its preparation.
Ingredients
1 litre full-fat milk
3 tablespoons raw rice
4 tablespoons sugar or jaggery
1 tablespoon ghee
10–12 cashews
1 tablespoon raisins

Method
Cook milk and rice together on low heat for a long duration, stirring occasionally. Gradually, the milk thickens and takes on a natural pinkish hue—a sign of slow caramelization. In ghee, roast cashews and raisins, then add them along with the sweetener. Let it simmer gently, absorbing every layer of flavor.

What you get is not just payasam — It is depth, warmth, and time itself. Kheer teaches something we often forget. To slow down. To wait. To nurture.

Even today, as modern kitchens experiment with millets, jaggery, and new-age flavors, the heart returns to the original. A simple pot. A slow flame. A familiar aroma. Because kheer is not just India's oldest dessert. It is a feeling.

From Vedic rituals to royal indulgence, from temple offerings to your own kitchen, it has travelled through centuries without losing its essence. In every spoonful lies history. In every aroma, a memory. And in every bowl, a quiet reminder— Some things are not meant to change. Only to be savoured.



(Sherry Bhatnagar is a passionate food storyteller with deep roots in Indian regional cuisine, the author writes where memory, migration, and the kitchen intersect. Having lived across cultures yet firmly anchored in Indian flavours, her work explores food not just as nourishment, but as identity, tradition, and lived experience—told with honesty, restraint, and quiet depth.)

April 2026



Richa Pathak

April doesn't rush you, but it definitely moves you. After a phase of thinking and waiting, you'll notice situations slowly aligning. This is not a loud breakthrough month—it's a settling month, where decisions feel clearer and your energy feels more in control.

Aries (Mar 21 – Apr 19)
This month brings you back into your natural rhythm. You feel more decisive, but also more aware of consequences. Work begins to move, but only when you stay patient with timing. In relationships, avoid reacting instantly—your silence will solve more than your words. **Lucky Color:** Scarlet **Lucky Day:** Tuesday **Remedy:** Offer water to the rising Sun for steady focus.

Taurus (Apr 20 – May 20)
You may not see big changes externally, but internally you're becoming stronger and clearer. Financial thinking improves, and you begin choosing stability over comfort. Emotionally, you need honesty—both from yourself and others. **Lucky Color:** Moss Green **Lucky Day:** Friday **Remedy:** Light a ghee lamp in the evening for calm and grounding.

Gemini (May 21 – Jun 20)
Your mind is active, but this month teaches you to filter what truly matters. A conversation or idea can open a door, but only if you stay focused. Avoid saying yes to everything—you'll do better when you choose carefully. **Lucky Color:** Lemon Yellow **Lucky Day:** Wednesday **Remedy:** Keep a small green plant near your workspace.

Cancer (Jun 21 – Jul 22)
You are slowly stepping into emotional control. Situations at home or work that felt heavy earlier now seem manageable. Don't overthink what is already improving. Protect your peace—distance from unnecessary stress will help you grow faster. **Lucky Color:** Pearl White **Lucky Day:** Monday **Remedy:** Keep rock salt in your room and change it weekly.

Leo (Jul 23 – Aug 22)
This month brings attention, but how you handle it matters. You don't need to prove anything—your presence is enough. Work opportunities may come, but consistency will decide results. In personal life, soften your tone. **Lucky Color:** Golden Yellow **Lucky Day:** Sunday **Remedy:** Offer water to the Sun for clarity and confidence.



Virgo (Aug 23 – Sep 22)
April asks you to simplify your life. Not everything needs fixing. Once you reduce pressure on yourself, work and health both improve. You may realise that balance matters more than perfection. **Lucky Color:** Olive Green **Lucky Day:** Thursday **Remedy:** Add turmeric to bathwater once a week.

Libra (Sep 23 – Oct 22)
Relationships reflect your inner balance this month. Where you are clear, things flow. Where you are confused, things feel stuck. Honest communication will bring relief. Financially, stability builds slowly. Lucky Color: Peach Lucky Day: Friday Remedy: Keep fresh flowers in your home.

Scorpio (Oct 23 – Nov 21)
You are quietly transforming. You may not say much, but internally a lot is changing. This is a good time to make practical decisions, especially related to work and money. Avoid emotional extremes—stay grounded. **Lucky Color:** Deep Red **Lucky Day:** Tuesday **Remedy:** Burn a bay leaf to release mental stress.

Sagittarius (Nov 22 – Dec 21)
You feel ready for something new, but this month asks you to stay consistent before jumping ahead. A new idea or plan can work well if you stay committed. Avoid distractions—they will delay your progress. **Lucky Color:** Indigo **Lucky Day:** Thursday **Remedy:** Keep a yellow item near your study or work area.

Capricorn (Dec 22 – Jan 19)
Responsibilities continue, but you are handling them better now. You may feel the need to slow down emotionally, even if work remains steady. Don't ignore rest—it will help you stay strong for what's coming next. **Lucky Color:** Grey **Lucky Day:** Saturday **Remedy:** Write weekly goals and review them regularly.

Aquarius (Jan 20 – Feb 18)
Your thinking is changing, and that's a good sign. You may approach situations differently this month. Communication improves, and people start understanding your ideas better. Stay consistent with your efforts. **Lucky Color:** Blue **Lucky Day:** Wednesday **Remedy:** Keep a bowl of water in the north direction.

Pisces (Feb 19 – Mar 20)
This month brings clarity in areas where you felt unsure. Financial thinking becomes practical, and you start trusting your instincts more. Avoid emotional decisions, especially in money matters. You are more stable than you think. **Lucky Color:** Sea Green **Lucky Day:** Friday **Remedy:** Apply sandalwood for calmness and focus.

(Astrologer Richa Pathak masters the art of Astrology, Vastu & Numerology. In-person consultation with prior appointment can be done at 207, Lantana, Nahar Amrit Shakti, Chandivali, Powai. She also gives Virtual Consultation & can be reached @ 8452920640 & www.jyotishdham.com)